

General Knowledge

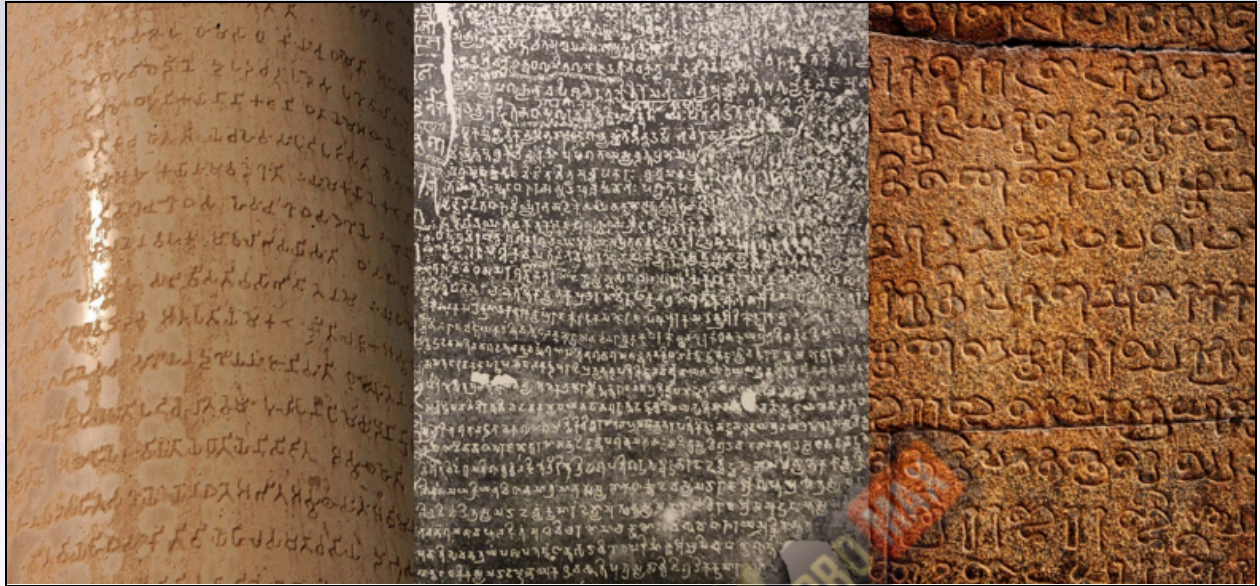
Art & Culture

STUDY NOTES

Edicts and Inscriptions



EDICTS AND INSCRIPTIONS



Introduction

- **Edicts** are proclamations or orders issued by a ruler or authority for public knowledge.
- They are **primarily focused on communicating policies, rules, or ethical principles** for governance.
- **Inscriptions** are writings engraved on durable surfaces, such as stones, metals, or clay, for historical, religious, or commemorative purposes.
- They serve as **historical records** to commemorate **events, achievements, conquests, and donations**.

Key Differences Between Edicts and Inscriptions:

Aspect	Edicts	Inscriptions
Definition	Public proclamations issued by rulers or authorities.	Writings engraved on surfaces for historical purposes.
Purpose	Spread policies, rules, and ethical principles.	Document events, achievements, or donations.

Content	Policy-oriented; focuses on governance and morals.	Historical narratives, eulogies, and genealogies.
Medium	Found on pillars, rocks, and walls in public spaces.	Found on temples, tombs, artefacts, and coins .
Example	Ashoka's Major Rock Edict XIII on peace and war.	Mehrauli Iron Pillar commemorating Chandragupta II.

Ashokan Edicts and Inscriptions

- **Emperor Ashoka**, a Maurya dynasty ruler, embraced **Buddhism** after witnessing the devastation caused by the **Kalinga War**.
- To spread **Buddha's teachings and Dhamma**, Ashoka inscribed **pillar edicts, rock edicts, and cave inscriptions** in various parts of his empire, covering present-day **India, Nepal, Pakistan, Bangladesh, and Afghanistan**.
- **Ashoka's Dhamma** was not just a religion but a way of life, emphasizing **non-violence, compassion, truthfulness, and social welfare**.

Types of Ashokan Edicts

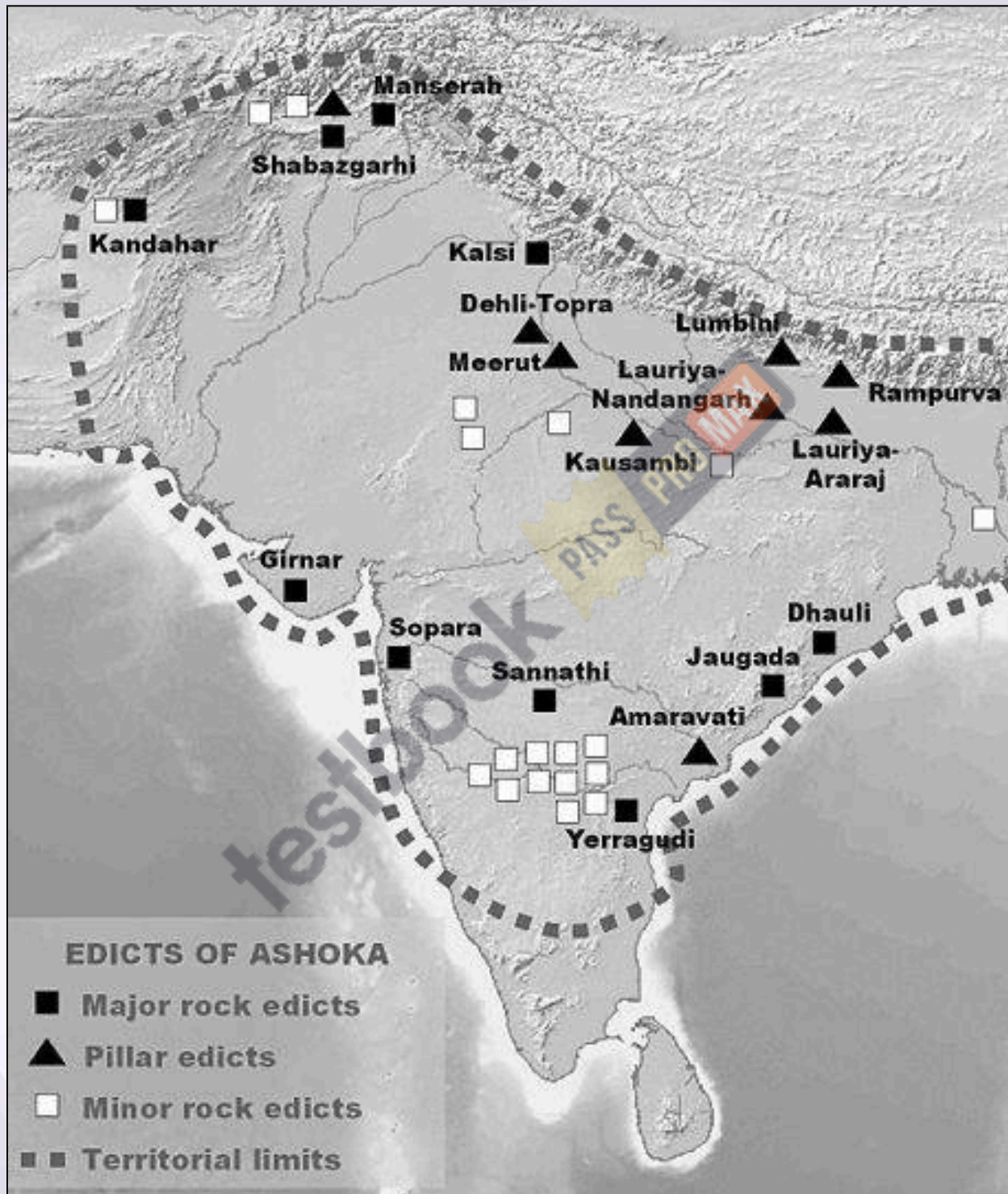
- **Major Rock Edicts:**
 - Inscribed on large rocks at the borders of Ashoka's empire, containing **ethical instructions** and governance principles.
- **Minor Rock Edicts:**
 - Found in **Maski, Brahmagiri, Sasaram, Rupanath, and Bhabru-Bairat**, these inscriptions detail Ashoka's personal beliefs and his conversion to **Buddhism**.
- **Major Pillar Edicts:**
 - Written during Ashoka's later reign on **polished stone pillars**, focusing on **Dhamma principles, governance, and non-violence**.
- **Minor Pillar Edicts:**
 - These include **Queen's edicts** and **Schism edicts**, found on a smaller scale across Ashoka's empire.

Notable Rock Edicts of Ashoka

Edict	Feature
Major Rock Edict I	Prohibits animal sacrifice during celebrations.
Major Rock Edict II	Mentions South Indian kingdoms and focuses on medical care and welfare.
Major Rock Edict III	Ensures freedom for Brahmanas and encourages officials to promote Dhamma.
Major Rock Edict IV	Prefers the sound of Dhamma (peace) over the sound of war.
Major Rock Edict V	Orders kind treatment for slaves and appointment of Dhamma Mahamatras .
Major Rock Edict XIII	Describes the transformation of Ashoka after the Kalinga War , advocating peace.
Major Rock Edict XIV	Explains the purpose of inscriptions and their placement.

Notable Pillar Edicts of Ashoka

Edict	Feature
Pillar Edict I	States Ashoka's principles for protecting people.
Pillar Edict V	Lists animals and plants protected by Ashoka and describes the release of prisoners .
Pillar Edict VII	Promotes tolerance towards all religions.
Rummindei Pillar Edict	Documents Ashoka's visit to Lumbini , Buddha's birthplace.
Nigali Sagar Pillar Edict	Mentions raising the height of Kanakamuni Buddha's shrine .



Ashokan Edicts: Languages and Locations

- **Languages Used:**
 - **Prakrit, Aramaic, and Greek.**
 - Most inscriptions were in **Prakrit**, written in **Brahmi script**.
 - **Kharosthi script** was used in **Mansehra and Shabazgiri**.
- **Locations:**
 - It is found in **Delhi, Sarnath, Allahabad, Kandahar, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, Vaishali, Amaravati, and Sanchi**.

Significance of Ashokan Edicts and Inscriptions

- **Ashoka's edicts** emphasized moral conduct, compassion, and **non-violence**, promoting **Dhamma** across his empire.
- These inscriptions played a pivotal role in **governance** by spreading messages of **welfare and religious tolerance**.
- **Placed along highways and trade routes**, they ensured accessibility to the public.
- The **Ashokan edicts** are some of the earliest **public records**, showcasing **ethical governance and civic responsibility**.

Important Inscriptions and Edicts

Inscription/Edict	Location	Period	Significance
Sohgaura Copper Plate	Uttar Pradesh	Mauryan Period	References famine relief efforts ; pre-Ashoka Brahmi inscription.
Rummindei Pillar Edicts	Lumbini, Nepal	Ashokan Period	Records Ashoka's pilgrimage to Lumbini; exempts the region from taxes.
Mehrauli Iron Pillar	Qutub Minar, Delhi	Gupta Period	Celebrates Chandragupta II's conquests ; made from rust-resistant metal.

Allahabad Pillar	Allahabad, Uttar Pradesh	Multiple Periods	Contains Ashokan, Samudragupta, and Jahangir's inscriptions.
Kalsi Inscription	Dehradun, Uttarakhand	Ashokan Period	Features the only complete set of Ashoka's 14 edicts in North India.
Maski Inscription	Karnataka	Ashokan Period	First inscription mentioning Ashoka by name ; promotes Buddhist principles .
Kalinga Edicts	Odisha	Ashokan Period	Reflects Ashoka's transformation post-Kalinga War and adoption of non-violence.
Aihole Inscriptions	Karnataka	Chalukya Period	Mentions Pulakeshin II's victory over Harshavardhana; written in Sanskrit and Kannada script.
Junagarh Inscription	Gujarat	2nd Century AD	Describes the construction of the Sudarshana Lake dam and repairs under Skandagupta.
Nasik Inscription	Maharashtra	Satavahana Period	Documents Gautamiputra Satakarni's achievements and victory over the Sakas.
Hathigumpha Inscription	Udayagiri-Khandagiri, Odisha	2nd Century BCE	Provides a year-by-year account of Kharavela's reign ; a key source of Jain history.
Ben Sagar Inscription	Vidisha, Madhya Pradesh	Sunga Period	Greek ambassador Heliodorus's dedication to Lord Vasudev ; written in Prakrit and Brahmi script.

Other Inscriptions in Ancient India

Inscription/Edict	Location	Period	Significance
-------------------	----------	--------	--------------

Bhattiprolu Inscription	Andhra Pradesh	3rd century BCE	The earliest Brahmi script found in South India; reflects early Buddhism.
Bharhut Inscriptions	Madhya Pradesh	2nd century BCE	Contains Buddhist inscriptions; and records donations for Bharhut Stupa.
Gwalior Inscription	Madhya Pradesh	875 CE	Documents building of a tank by Mihira Bhoja of the Gurjara-Pratihara dynasty.
Amarkantak Inscription	Madhya Pradesh	11th century CE	Records the donation by Karna of the Kalachuri dynasty to Brahmins.
Mandsaur Inscription	Madhya Pradesh	5th century CE	Eulogizes Kumargupta I; mentions the construction of a Vishnu temple .
Sanchi Stupa Inscriptions	Madhya Pradesh	2nd century BCE	Highlights donations for the construction of the Sanchi Stupa.
Udayagiri Inscriptions	Madhya Pradesh	5th century CE	Mentions the reign of Chandragupta II and the development of Vaishnavism.
Naneghat Inscription	Maharashtra	1st century BCE	Documents Satavahana queen Naganika's sacrifices for religious rituals.
Halmidi Inscription	Karnataka	450 CE	Earliest record in Kannada language ; marks the beginning of Kannada epigraphy.
Belur Inscription	Karnataka	12th century CE	Mentions Hoysala king Vishnuvardhana's reign and temple donations.

Tirukkural Inscription	Tamil Nadu	Chola period	Engraved verses of Tirukkural on temple walls, highlighting Tamil literature.
Tiruvalangadu Copper Plates	Tamil Nadu	11th century CE	Records the conquests of Chola King Rajendra I.
Kudumiyanmalai Inscription	Tamil Nadu	7th century CE	Contains musical notes on the Pallava dynasty's patronage of music.
Karle Inscription	Maharashtra	1st century BCE	Inscriptions in Karle Caves mentioning Satavahana donations.
Girnar Inscription	Gujarat	2nd century CE	Written by Rudradaman; mentions repairs to Sudarshana Lake.
Gorathgiri Inscription	Uttar Pradesh	1st century CE	Records Buddhist donations in the Kushana period.
Jambai Inscription	Tamil Nadu	1st century CE	The earliest reference to the Sangam Chera dynasty in Tamil Nadu.
Mahabalipuram Inscription	Tamil Nadu	7th century CE	Describes Pallava dynasty's maritime activities.
Agastya Inscription	Tamil Nadu	10th century CE	References the legend of Sage Agastya and southward migration of Vedic culture.
Nalanda Copper Plate	Bihar	9th century CE	Records donations to the Nalanda University by King Devapala.
Bhimbetka Rock Shelters	Madhya Pradesh	Prehistoric period	Contains prehistoric paintings and inscriptions , documenting early human life.

Rajatarangini Inscription	Jammu & Kashmir	12th century CE	References historical events documented by Kalhana in Rajatarangini.
Rajasimha Pallava Inscription	Tamil Nadu	8th century CE	Describes the reign of Rajasimha Pallava and temple patronage.
Erukal Inscription	Andhra Pradesh	3rd century CE	Mentions early Buddhist monasteries and royal patronage.
Talagunda Inscription	Karnataka	5th century CE	Mentions the origin of the Kadamba dynasty and King Mayurasharman.
Ghatiyala Inscription	Rajasthan	861 CE	Mentions Pratihara King Bhoja I and his conquests.
Ajanta Caves Inscriptions	Maharashtra	5th century CE	Records donations by Vakataka dynasty kings and merchants for the caves.
Modhera Sun Temple Inscription	Gujarat	11th century CE	Mentions the construction of the Sun Temple by Solanki King Bhima I.
Bodh Gaya Inscription	Bihar	5th century CE	Mentions King Meghavarna of Sri Lanka's visit to Bodh Gaya and his contributions.
Kashi Copper Plates	Uttar Pradesh	10th century CE	Mentions donations to temples during the reign of King Govinda Chandra .
Hanumangarh Inscription	Rajasthan	2nd century BCE	Mentions early Buddhist activities during the Indo-Scythian period.